Minxuan (Martin) Cao

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mc286@uw.edu | Portfolio

Education

B.S. in Psychology; Minor in Education, Learning & Society Sep 2024-Present
University of Washington | Seattle, WA

- GPA: 3.88/4.00; Psychology Honors Program; Dean's List, 2024-2026.

Research and Design Interests: Human factors, human-AI and embodied interaction, UX research, behavioral product design, and responsible AI.

Selected Human-Centered Design Projects

Holding Together 2026
Independent HCI Researcher and Physical Interaction Designer

- Synthesized 25 sources on loneliness, social touch, embodied interaction, and AI companionship into a critical review and design requirements for a home embracing device; distinguished published findings from untested product hypotheses.
- Developed a consistent torso-and-arm concept, material cutaway, dimensional targets, mass budget, and staged evaluation plan. Designed live partner voice with separate touch consent and an offline interaction demo; hardware and real calling remain unvalidated.

Waiting With You 2026-Present
Independent Product Designer and Developer | Python, Streamlit

- Mapped candidate and recruiter journeys, identifying application silence and ambiguous status as consequential parts of the hiring experience.
- Built a two-sided runnable prototype with staged status explanations, supportive messaging, and refresh tracking; AI responses and email delivery remain simulated.

IP Alive 2026-Present
Independent Human-AI Product Researcher, Designer, and Developer | React Native, Expo, TypeScript

- Collected 165 exploratory survey responses (150 valid) on owners' connection to physical character collectibles; translated findings into design hypotheses and requirements.
- Built a high-fidelity prototype spanning conversation, memory, events, travel, customization, and games; defined privacy, attachment, memory, and monetization boundaries. Production AI, persistent storage, and payments are not connected.

Pause With You 2026
Independent Human Factors Researcher and Physical Product Designer

- Reviewed pharmacological, sensorimotor, visual, ritual, and contextual functions of smoking; decomposed the interaction into 12 steps to derive requirements for a nicotine-free, non-combustion concept without inhalation through the device.
- Separated user-air, water, and control pathways and defined fail-safe and staged validation requirements; made no safety or cessation-effectiveness claims.

Research Experience

Psychology Honors Program Dec 2025-Present
Department of Psychology, University of Washington | Seattle, WA

- Developed a study of four ACL-inspired dyadic conversations for people awaiting employment, internship, or further-education decisions; prepared eligibility criteria, measures, recruitment, session structure, and staff training before data collection.

Research Assistant Sep 2025-Present
Center for the Science of Social Connection, University of Washington | Seattle, WA

- Contributed to protocol testing, recruitment, session-data preparation, transcript cleaning, descriptive analysis, and figures for a four-session trauma-informed ACL pilot; fourth author on the published article.
- Completed approximately 100 hours of FAP/ACL training under Mavis Tsai, Ph.D., focused on behavioral observation and present-moment interpersonal processes; supported onboarding and training of laboratory members.

Research Experience (continued)

Research Assistant Jul 2025-Sep 2025

Yang Lab, Beijing Normal University | Beijing, China

- Supported fNIRS and behavioral research with students in Grades 2-5 experiencing reading and attention-related challenges; prepared sessions, administered supervised measures, and supported pre/post data processing while monitoring clarity, fatigue, comfort, and equipment setup.

Product and User Experience

Product Support and Psychology Intern Jun 2026-Sep 2026

Changsha Hongjun Technology Co., Ltd. | Changsha, China / Remote

- Annotated and quality-checked multimodal AI data using facial action units and behavioral and psychological coding, translating interpretations into operational labels for product workflows.
- Supported psychological measurement, interface and visual design in JS Design, and audiovisual production using DaVinci Resolve and CapCut.

User Experience Specialist and Psychology Support Consultant Dec 2025-Present

Kemi Online Counseling Platform | Remote

- Identified recurring usability issues through direct user interactions and reported recommendations to the technical lead; applied FAP- and SFBT-informed listening in student mental-health and career-stress contexts.

Psychiatric Department Intern Mar 2024-Sep 2024

Changzhou De'an Hospital | Changzhou, China

- Assisted under supervision with psychological scales and cognitive assessments; observed ward rounds, shift handoffs, and emergency clinical workflows.

Publications and Presentations

Mattingly, L. C., Figueroa, B., Barsy, A., **Cao, M.**, Mills, A., & Tsai, M. (2026). From isolation to connection: A trauma-informed Awareness, Courage & Love pilot intervention for adults with adverse childhood experiences. *Medical Research Archives, 14*(9). https://doi.org/10.18103/mra.2026.0537

Cao, M. (2023). An investigation of social factors contributing to unrealistic self-assessment. *International Journal of Education and Humanities, 10*(1), 178-180. doi:10.54097/ijeh.v10i1.11114

Oral Presentation on Eating Disorders and Body-Image Anxiety 2026

Online Academic Conference

- Introduced three eating disorders, emphasizing binge-eating disorder and anorexia nervosa; critically examined appearance and body-image anxiety.

Leadership

Director of Planning; Interim President Jun 2025-Jun 2026

HuaPsychology Club | Seattle, WA

- Created the planning department's first SOP and leadership handbook, led cross-department documentation, organized a university-level new-student event, and recruited, trained, and mentored undergraduates.

Skills and Training

Research: Experimental design, focused review, recruitment, exploratory surveys, behavioral coding, psychometrics, transcript preparation, data visualization, and fNIRS data collection.

Design: Journey mapping, task decomposition, interaction design, prototyping, requirements, usability-test planning, and safety and ethics analysis.

Programming and Analysis: Python, R, MATLAB, SPSS, jamovi, Excel, and Git/GitHub.

Media: JS Design, DaVinci Resolve, and CapCut.

Relevant Training: Functional Analytic Psychotherapy, Solution-Focused Brief Therapy, and Acceptance and Commitment Therapy.

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (TOEFL 108), Cantonese Chinese (conversational).